Telephone Man

By Chris Crutcher

JACK: "Eccentric" is what the teachers at Oakland High School call kids they think are crazy. They use words like that so people like me won't know what they're really saying. Around this school they call me Telephone Man, which is one of the few things I like, even though I know they think I'm a dork for wearing telephone equipment strapped to my hip. But without it, I feel like how the Duke must feel when they make him check his six-shooter at the saloon door. I feel bare naked.

I can fix any telephone that a regular telephone man can fix. I can fix it if the people on the other end can't hear you or if you can't hear them. And if you have more than one phone in your place, I can set them up like walkie-talkies, if they have the right stuff in 'em. That's what I can do.

INTRODUCTION

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JACK: Sometimes I wish Hawk wouldn't of saved me from the China kids because it confuses me, and I hate that most of all. When a nigger goes saving you from Chinamen, it throws you off because everyone knows niggers are the worst. It all happened on one of those days when I just don't think. That's what my mom and dad both say: "Jack, most of the time you get into trouble because you just don't think." I got up late that day, and it looked like I would have to go to school without breakfast again. Well, Mom was still in bed and the bus was coming in about four minutes and I looked through the cupboards and I couldn't find anything except there was the Bisquick. Well, I knew that's what Mom made

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biscuits out of, and I figured, hey, even if they don't taste as good not cooked, they have to be just as good for you, right? I mean, your stomach doesn't know if they're cooked. Everything turns about the same temperature pretty quick down there anyway. There wasn't any strawberry jam in the fridge, so I just ate the Bisquick right out of the box, which it was pretty dry. But then, when I was in the bathroom trying to blast off a pimple from my nose that looked about like a spaceship or something, I saw this strawberry stuff sitting on the bathtub, and I didn't know why it was there; but I did figure it was no big deal if I ate it after the biscuits because like I said before, it all ends up in the same place anyway and your stomach would never know which order you ate it in. Right?

I think it should be against the law to make soap or shampoo that smells like jam and has pictures of strawberries on the front. I mean, it was red and it was thick, and even though it didn't have clumps of strawberries in it and it tasted funny, it looked like syrup, which is close enough to jam to drink when you're in a hurry and just want to get something close to your regular breakfast in you.

Well, what went on inside me probably would of made a good science lesson, I bet. I didn't know how many biscuits you can make out of one box of Bisquick, but I found out later it's a lot. And I also didn't know what happens when you get soap inside you.

I was in history when it hit. There was this sort of rumbling inside me, and all of a sudden I knew I had to get to the bathroom really quick, so I just ran for it. I was lucky enough to get my telephone stuff off and up high out of the way, but right after I did that, I started feeling like a balloon that you just let go of the end. I wanted to save my clothes, and I got my shirt off, but my pants got stuck

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down around my knees right when my butt just turned into a cannon and I was shooting biscuit stuff all over the whole room.

So everything would of been okay except on my way to the bus I ran into the China kids. The China kids hang out at the top of the stairs, and if they're going to get you, that's where they do it. I saw them there, and right away I was going to go back; but our school bell rings outside and inside, and I heard it and I knew the kids would be changing classes and some of them would come outside and see me if I tried to go back the other way-and I thought they'd know what I did in the bathroom. I think people just know if you mess up sometimes, even if no one tells them. So anyway, I decided to just go ahead and pretend I didn't see the China kids and maybe they'd just let me go to the bus so I could go change my clothes.

But they didn't. The leader, he's a guy named Kam, was practicing that karate stuff, and the rest of his gang was clapping their hands and saying "way to go." They call theirselves the Jo-Boys. That's a really dumb name, and I don't get it; but I wasn't going to say anything. I just put my head down and walked around the corner to the steps, trying to make it like no one could see me. I can do that sometimes, but not this time. Somebody said, "Hey, kid!" but I just put my head down farther and kept walking. I tried to do it like when you're trying to get past a mean dog. My dad told me not to walk any faster or anything, just to act like I'm not there. But this kid wasn't a dog, and he said, "Hey, kid," again. I tried to walk faster; but somebody grabbed my shoulder, and I turned around toward him and said, "You better leave me alone," but I kept my head down.

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But he said, "Well, yeah, but these are our stairs, and we have to charge you to go down 'em," and I said I don't have any money, which was a little bit of a lie because I had enough for lunch, but my dad told me to always say I don't have any.

Then the kid who talked to me first says, "What's that you got around your waist?" and I tell him it's my telephone stuff. He wants to know what it's worth, and I tell him it's not for sale; but he just laughs, and Kam tells me to take it off. Now, I'm scared a lot of the time, and most of the time I'm afraid to talk because people just make fun of me because I have this really deep voice and these stupid zits on my nose plus it's hard to get the words in my head out so they sound right. But they want my telephone stuff, and they're just not going to get it. They're just not. I'm almost nobody anyway, but if I don't have my telephone stuff, I'm really nobody. Absolutely, completely, and all the way nobody. So I scream, "Leave me alone!" and they start laughing and kind of pushing me between each other. I grab the buckle to my telephone belt and hold on to it tight, and they push me harder, and they start sort of singing, "Leave me alone, leave me alone, leave me alone," so I scream it at them again, only louder this time, and I keep my eyes closed really tight and hold on to my belt buckle with all my might. Sometimes if I scream and scream and keep my eyes closed tight, things just get over.

Then all of a sudden everything stops, and I think maybe it worked, but I keep my eyes closed a little bit longer because sometimes that makes sure everyone goes away. Then I open them just a little and take a peek to see if it's time to get up and run yet.

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But what I see is Hawk, and I know I'm done for. See, Hawk is this big nigger that goes to OMLC, and everybody knows if he's after you, you might as well buy a plot in a cemetery somewhere because he might just be the toughest guy in the world. He's never teased me before. Usually Hawk just walks up to me and says something like "Telephone Man, you a kick," and he smiles and shakes his head and walks away.

But now I get it. He gets the China kids to beat me up a little, and then he comes along to finish me off. I think, so that's his nigger trick, and I roll up into a ball because now I know it won't be very long until it's all over.

But then I hear him say, "What you Jo-Boys think you doin' here?" and there's no answer. Then Hawk says, "This here's Telephone Man. Friend of mine," and still there's no answer. "How many time I gotta tell you China boys don' go be messin' with my friends?"

Kam starts breathing big and kind of crouching like an animal; but right before you know it, Hawk's got him down on the ground, and he doesn't get to use any of his karate stuff because Hawk's choking him right to death. The China kid's eyes are so big they're about ready to explode, and Hawk's only using one hand, 'cause he's looking at all these other China guys, who must be thinking they should jump on his back and help out their friend. But nobody does it; they just stand there and Hawk says,

HAWK: "Come on. I be closin' off you number one Jo-Boy air-hole for him; then I take anybody else want some,"

JACK: And still nobody moves. Then Hawk turns back to Kam and says,

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HAWK: "Gonna let you up, China boy. Nice an' slow. You try any you Bruce Lee stuff, gonna embarrass you, front you friends,"

JACK: And he lets a little bit loose. Kam gets up kind of slow, and when he's about halfway, Hawk grabs him by his cheeks between his fingers and makes him look at me.

HAWK: "You see that boy? . . . Got all kinda telephone stuff on him?"

JACK: Kam doesn't say anything, so Hawk moves his head up and down for him, like he's saying yes, and then Hawk says,

HAWK: "You touch him, you touchin' me. Unnerstan'?"

JACK: Kam doesn't say anything again, so Hawk moves his head up and down again.

HAWK: "Now you Jo-Boys, get on. This over here be my school, an' you got no binnis here."

JACK: Hawk walks me down the stairs to the bus stop then starts walking back up the stairs. When he gets about halfway back up, he turns and says,

HAWK: "Hey, Telephone Man," *(grinning)* "You a kick. An' you right. Don' be lettin' nobody get that telephone stuff off you. That's you one big thing."

JACK: So then I'm on the bus and no niggers beat me up like they were supposed to. In fact, they helped me, and so now what was I supposed to do? I quit worrying about it for a while, though, because there was this awful smell, like somebody hung a bunch of strawberries down in the sewer, and I figured out I wasn't all done in that rest room and probably getting beat up made me quit paying attention and I had gone and messed up the sweats Willie Weaver got for me out of the Lost and Found. I'm pretty sure the people around me noticed it because of the way they looked at me and then how the ones with perfectly good seats got up to stand near the back of the bus. So I got out at the next stop and walked on home. While I walked, I got to think a little bit, which is something I don't usually like to do because it makes me feel nervous, and I wondered if my

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dad would mind if I stopped hating niggers for a while. I really love my dad and I wouldn't stop if he said not to, and I wasn't going to ask him right out because I didn't want to disappoint him – but if my dad made a mistake about them, I wonder if he could of made a mistake about the other colors, too.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
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